

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "The Stainless"

Ārya Vimala Nāma Dhāraṇī · Toh 871 · Derge Kangyur

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The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "The Stainless" (Sanskrit: Ārya Vimala Nāma Dhāraṇī; Tibetan: 'Phags pa dri ma med pa zhes bya ba'i gzungs) is a short scriptural discourse centered on a dhāraṇī, a protective formula of the kind that is recited for spiritual benefit. It is set at Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak, where the Buddha addresses the bodhisattva Viśuddhamati, explaining that the Tathāgata is completely pure because each of his qualities, among them moral discipline, meditative absorption, patience, and loving-kindness, is itself completely pure. The text thus joins a reflection on the perfected purity of a buddha with the practice of reciting a dhāraṇī named for that stainlessness. It is Toh 871 in the Kangyur, the Tibetan canon of translated words of the Buddha, and belongs to the class of dhāraṇī texts found among the tantra section.

In Sanskrit: Ārya Vimala Nāma Dhāraṇī. In Tibetan: The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "The Stainless."

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak. Then the Blessed One spoke to the bodhisattva Viśuddhamati:

"Viśuddhamati, because his moral discipline is completely pure, the Tathāgata is completely pure. Viśuddhamati, because his meditative absorption is completely pure, the Tathāgata is completely pure. Viśuddhamati, because his patience is completely pure, the Tathāgata is completely pure. Viśuddhamati, because his acts of benefit are completely pure, the Tathāgata is completely pure. Viśuddhamati, because his loving-kindness is completely pure, the Tathāgata is completely pure. Viśuddhamati, because his compassion is completely pure, his joy is completely pure, and his equanimity is completely pure, the Tathāgata is completely pure. Viśuddhamati, because his liberation is completely pure, and his knowledge and vision of liberation are completely pure, the Tathāgata is completely pure. Viśuddhamati, because his powers are completely pure, his fearlessnesses are completely pure, and his buddha qualities are completely pure, the Tathāgata is completely pure. Viśuddhamati, because his omniscient wisdom is completely pure, the Tathāgata is completely pure.

"Viśuddhamati, whoever honors the Tathāgata, who is thus completely pure, with flowers, garlands, incense, parasols, victory banners and the like, with the sound of music, and with unguents, the limit of that person's mass of merit cannot be fathomed. As for its limit, apart from its culminating in nirvāṇa through any one of the three vehicles, that mass of merit cannot be exhausted even to the end of time.

"Why is that? Viśuddhamati, just as all the buddha qualities of the Tathāgata are immeasurable, so too are offerings made to the Tathāgata immeasurable. They are limitless. They are inconceivable. They are incomparable. They are countless. They are beyond reckoning. They are inexpressible.

"Viśuddhamati, there are those who honor, revere, esteem, worship, and venerate a Tathāgata who is present now, living and abiding. And in a later time, in the final five hundred years, there are those who honor, revere, esteem, worship, and venerate even a mustard-seed-sized relic of a Tathāgata who has passed into complete nirvāṇa. With their minds rightly settled, and having generated a mind inclined toward awakening, they pay homage, prostrate, honor, revere, esteem, worship, venerate, supplicate, praise, and circumambulate. Such persons should be known to gain five benefits. What are the five? They become endowed with mindfulness; they become endowed with understanding; they become endowed with a sense of shame and conscience; they quickly come to see the buddhas, the blessed ones; and having seen them, they give rise to faith. These should be known as the five benefits.

"Beyond these, they should also be known to gain four qualities. What are the four? They retain each of the words taught by the Tathāgata; they practice those teachings just as they were taught; they come near to the buddhas, the blessed ones; and they are quickly born in a completely pure buddha field. They come to possess these four qualities.

"Viśuddhamati, a bodhisattva endowed with four qualities will not be overcome by Māra or by the divine sons of Māra's host. What are the four? Being of noble family; keeping the buddhas, the blessed ones, in mind from the very moment of birth; upholding the sacred Dharma in later times; and being always blessed by the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas. Viśuddhamati, a bodhisattva endowed with these four qualities will not be overcome by Māra or by the divine sons of Māra's host.

"Viśuddhamati, suppose someone who has rightly entered the vehicle of the bodhisattvas sees a stūpa of a Tathāgata, gives rise to faith, places both kneecaps on the ground, pays homage, and develops this devotion: 'Just as the Tathāgata's body is beautifully adorned with the thirty-two marks of a great being, so may I too obtain a body like that.' Viśuddhamati, the limit of that mass of merit cannot be told, because it abides in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. That mass of merit cannot be exhausted even by becoming a king, by becoming Śakra (Indra), by becoming Brahmā, by becoming a śrāvaka, by becoming a pratyekabuddha, or even by becoming an unsurpassed, perfectly complete buddha.

Why is that? Viśuddhamati, it is because that son or daughter of noble family has taken hold of an inconceivable heap of merit.

Viśuddhamati, it is like this. Suppose a Tathāgata who has fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening enters a city, a monastery, or a village. Wherever that Tathāgata goes, whether he is walking, standing, sitting, or teaching the Dharma, there is no being anywhere in the great trichiliocosm, the world system of a billion worlds, that does not bow toward the place where the Tathāgata is. Gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, mahoragas, humans and nonhumans all bow, bow deeply, and bow down entirely, and so do even the trees, the mountains, the caves, and the eaves of houses. Beings act this way toward the Tathāgata, who is endowed with all the roots of virtue. In the same way, when those sons or daughters of noble family move about in a village, a city, a market town, a district, or the precincts of a palace, beings will bow to them, bow deeply, and bow down entirely.

Homage to the Blessed One Amitābha!

amitā mate prabhe mahāprabhe prabhāvatī, prabhāvatī, prabhāvatī,
prabhāvatī, prabhāvatī, prabhāvatī, prabhāvatī, prabhāvatī, prabhāvatī,
prabhāvatī.

Blessed One, I pray, reveal it through your power! Blessed One, I pray, reveal it through your power!

tadyathā mati mati, mati mati, mati mati, mati mati, mati mati, smṛti, smṛti,
smṛti, smṛti, smṛti, smṛti, smṛti, smṛti, smṛti, smṛti, mahāsmṛti, mahāsmṛti,
mahāsmṛti.

You who are free of attachment, I pray, dispel delusion!

some, some, some, some, some, some, some, some, some, some,
saumanasya mupanaya, saumanasya mupanaya, saumanasya mupanaya,
saumanasya mupanaya, saumanasya mupanaya, saumanasya mupanaya,
saumanasya mupanaya, saumanasya mupanaya, saumanasya mupanaya,
saumanasya mupanaya, śikhi śikhi, śikhi śikhi, śikhi śikhi, śikhi śikhi, śikhi śikhi, śikhi śikhi.

May there be peace! May there be no illness! May there be no obstructors!

prabhāvatī mahāmatye raśmi, raśmi, raśmi, raśmi, raśmi, raśmi, raśmi, raśmi,
raśmi, raśmi.

One should also hold in mind the names of these buddhas, the blessed ones, and pay homage to them. They are as follows: the Blessed One Source of Jewels, the Blessed One Jewel Sun, the Blessed One Supreme Jewel, the Blessed One Solid Jewel, the Blessed One Jewel Crest, the Blessed One Jewel Radiating Light, the Blessed One Jewel Might, the Blessed One Akṣobhya, the Blessed One Amitābha, the Blessed One Boundless Voice, the Blessed One Hard to Overcome, the Blessed One Infinite Renown, the Blessed One Jewel Light, the Blessed One Attainer of Great Bliss, the Blessed One Starlight, the Blessed One True Voice, the Blessed One Free from the Stain of Illness, the Blessed One White Moon, the Blessed One Stainless Light, the Blessed One White Sun, the Blessed One Sunlight, the Blessed One Pure Light, the Blessed One Infinite Jewel, the Blessed One Jewel Essence, the Blessed One Jewel Origin, the Blessed One Moon Lamp, the Blessed One Lotus Host, the Blessed One Lotus Sound, the Blessed One Supreme Lotus, the Blessed One Supreme Quality, the Blessed One Golden Light, the Blessed One King Lord of Brahmā, the Blessed One Golden Appearance, the Blessed One Source of Gold, the Blessed One King Lord of Nāgas, the Blessed One Flower, the Blessed One King Lord of All Fragrances, the Blessed One King of Garlands, the Blessed One Host of Steadfast Heroes, the Blessed One Abandoner of Weapons, the Blessed One Glorious Essence Jewel Light, the Blessed One Light of Boundless Realization, the Blessed One Lion's Roar, the Blessed One King Lord of Lions, the Blessed One Great Might Diligent Renunciation, the Blessed One Overpowering by Essence, the Blessed One King of the Drum's Sound, the Blessed One Supreme Moon, the Blessed One Overpowering by Lotus, the Blessed One Lamp of the World, the Blessed One Fire, the Blessed One Terrifier, the Blessed One Jewel Rim, the Blessed One Ever Completely Passed into Nirvāṇa, the Blessed One Vast Intellect, the Blessed One Light of Infinite Jewel Emanations, the Blessed One Outshining like Sumeru, the Blessed One Supreme Jewel in Hand, the

Blessed One Glory of Gathered Jewels, the Blessed One Glory of the Words of the Precious Irreversible Wheel, the Blessed One All-Illuminating Who Has Attained Purity, the Blessed One Lamp of Sun and Moon, the Blessed One Meru, the Blessed One Great Meru, the Blessed One Sumeru, the Blessed One Supreme Meru, and the Blessed One Like Sumeru.

tadyathā pata pata dama dama ghama ghama svāhā.

I pay homage to the guides, these buddhas, the blessed ones, and all the others who dwell with their retinues in the eastern direction. I pray that they too protect me and my retinue, granting health and peace.

I pay homage to the guides, the buddhas, the blessed ones who dwell in the southern direction. I pray that they too protect me, granting health and peace.

I pay homage to the guides, the buddhas, the blessed ones who dwell in the western direction. I pray that they too protect me, granting health and peace.

I pay homage to the guides, the buddhas, the blessed ones who dwell in the northern direction.

May they too protect me, so that I am free of illness and at peace. I pay homage to the buddhas, the blessed guides, who dwell in the direction below. May they too protect me, so that I am free of illness and at peace. I pay homage to the buddhas, the blessed guides, who dwell in the direction above. May they too protect me, so that I am free of illness and at peace. I pay homage to the buddhas, the blessed guides, who dwell in the intermediate directions. May they too protect me, so that I am free of illness and at peace.

Tadyathā, vimale vimalākare vimalasaṃbhavā svāhā. Vimale vimale vimale vimale vimale vimale vimale vimale vimale. Vimalākare vimalākare vimalākare vimalākare vimalākare vimalākare vimalākare vimalākare vimalākare. Vimalasamudgate vimalasamudgate vimalasamudgate vimalasamudgate vimalasamudgate vimalasamudgate vimalasamudgate vimalasamudgate.

This vidyā-mantra is a great vidyā-mantra;

It was proclaimed by the gods.

If one recites it at the three times of day,

One is completely freed from illnesses.

Whatever has been done by nonhuman beings,

And whatever evils have been worked against one, it undoes.

Such people will not lose their memory,

And what they have retained will not be wasted.

In all their births as well,

They will never be parted from the buddhas.

Whoever joyfully holds

This Stainless dhāraṇī,

When roaming through all the buddha fields,

Will be born in the heart of a glorious lotus,

Beautifully adorned with the major marks,

With nets of light rays streaming from their limbs.

Tadyathā, kuṭi kuṭi kucchalo ela ela mukta kotthālo eriri raṁṛti svāhā.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the bodhisattva, the great being Viśuddhamati, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the noble dhāraṇī called The Stainless.

It was translated and edited by the Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla and the chief editor and translator, the venerable Yeshé Dé. It was then revised and finalized in accordance with the new language standard.

Translator's Notes

- The Tibetan name of the bodhisattva literally means "Completely Pure Intelligence." It is given here in its Sanskrit form, Viśuddhamati. The series of verbs of veneration (honoring, revering, esteeming, worshipping, venerating) translates a stock sequence of terms for showing respect. In "because it abides in unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening," the Tibetan leaves the subject unstated. It could also be read as the practitioner who abides in, or is set toward, awakening.
- The interlocutor's name, Blo gros nam par dag pa, is given as Viśuddhamati. Apart from the well-established names Akṣobhya and Amitābha, the buddha names in the list are rendered as English translations of the Tibetan, since their Sanskrit originals cannot be reconstructed with confidence. The mantra syllables are transliterated as the Tibetan gives them, including the irregular forms "amitā mate" and "saumanasya mupanaya" (perhaps for saumanasyam upanaya, "bring joy").
- The mantras are given in a reconstructed Sanskrit romanization. The second mantra contains several syllables of uncertain form, such as kucchalo, kotthālo and raṁṛti, which are transcribed as they stand in the Tibetan. "The three times" in the verse is taken to mean the three times of day, as it usually does in recitation instructions.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.